



MIGHTY MUSTANG

The North American P-51 Mustang was the most renowned American fighter of World War II. Its range and high performance enabled it to give Allied bombers an effective escort to targets deep inside Germany.

landings temporarily reduced the pressure on Germany in the early summer, the subsequent liberation of France rendered the Germans' defensive position ever more desperate. Even so, it took a long time and a lot of bombs to seriously affect Germany's ability to continue the war. Damage to transport links was countered by swift reconstruction; damage to industrial sites was limited by the relocation of key factories underground. But the targeting of fuel supplies, both through raids on the Ploesti oilfields of Romania and on factories in Germany manufacturing fuel out of coal, did eventually begin to cripple the German war machine.

Even before the fuel began to run out, the once-proud Luftwaffe was a shadow of its former self. Despite the destruction of aircraft factories in

Allied raids in the spring of 1944, German aircraft output actually reached its peak in that year, with 40,000 planes produced. But losses of pilots could not be made good as readily as losses of aircraft. As the war of attrition in the air took its toll, the Luftwaffe began throwing its pilots into combat with inadequate training. In general, neither German aircraft nor the men flying them were any longer a match for their enemies. Outnumbered and outfought, with their

PREPARED FOR TAKEOFF

A ground crewman gives the signal for a Mustang to take off. The use of a Merlin liquid-cooled engine, like that in the Spitfire, gave the Mustang a very different look from most US fighters, which had air-cooled radial engines.

